I Watched My Father Die – A Collection

By Ollie Schminkey

(Pg 20-21) ERASURE OF MY FATHER'S HEALTH CARE DIRECTIVE

TO MY FAMILY, DOCTORS, AND ALL THOSE CONCERNED WITH MY CARE:

make *known*
I want to die
in the event of _____
let me die.
If at any time I should have an incurable injury, disease, illness, or condition
let me die.
I direct I be permitted to die naturally
If I am unconscious and on life-support machines
let me die.
If _____
let me die.
If _____
let me die.
let me die.
let me die.

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INTRODUCTION

The way our society talks or refuses to talk about death left Ollie Schminkey unprepared for all the things they would have to do to help their dad die. Ollie is adamant: "My dad didn't 'pass on,' he died, while I watched." And the process was harder than they ever imagined it could be. "There was no last word, no wisdom, no wind, nothing to blow open our grief."

I Watched My Father Die – A Collection by Ollie Schminkey from Dead Dad Jokes

(Pg 48-49) YET ANOTHER POEM ABOUT ROADKILL

for people, we use words like, *distended, wound care, hypertension.*
for roadkill, we use words like, *disgusting, dead, wrecked.*
when are we saying what we really mean?

my father's bones disappear beneath his thick skin,
muscle replaced with water. he retains so much water
it bleeds from his skin, like condensation dripping down a window.
his legs swell like a hotdog in the microwave about to burst.
he breathes in short gasps, whispers, *please god let me die.*
my father drinks a glass of milk on the couch,

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then becomes so weak his hands shake the glass out of his fingers,
and it smashes on the ground.
his feet are purple, like they have decided
to die before the rest of his body.
i rub lotion on his purple feet, all over the sores
that bubble up his calves to his knees.
i wrap his legs in new bandages, like they will hold him together.

for people, we use words like, *hospice, terminal illness, declining.*
for roadkill, we use words like, *flattened, gone.*

my father is so gone . . .
the morphine flattens his memory until he can't even
remember my name –

he always taught me that, when the dog can't walk
anymore, you take it out back with a shotgun.
end its misery, he would say.

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i wonder how many things he has loved,
only to look into their eyes,
his large hand cradling their soft and greying jawlines,
lean the gun against their sagging stomachs,
and pull the trigger.

i wonder how their limp bodies fell,
if he hugged them to his chest,
if he cried,
if he dug the hole before or after the animal turned into a body.

i sort his pills by the hour and wonder how he knew it was time?

the only difference between a dead dog and roadkill
is that the dog was loved.
but its body will bloat the same if left in the sun --
its body will rot the same --
either way, all i can do is drive past --
my father's body is on my way home.
his body is on the way to the store.
his body is on the way to everywhere i need to go --

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and i drive past, and the maggots bite into his eyes,
i drive past, and the sores on his legs widen,
i drive past, and his purple legs burn red in the sun,
and he splits, and the illness breaks a thousand
glasses until we live in a house of shards –

sometimes, i want to drag his body out back,
my small hand cradling his soft and greying jawline,
hold his face in my hand like a white dandelion
about to burst into wishes,
lean the gun,
and pull.

(Pg 58) SOMETIMES I WANT TO HURT PEOPLE WHO HAVE HURT ME

i post in the group chat that my dad died 20 minutes ago
and i get a string of 7 heart emojis.

the space between them feels like
the space between my own fingers where
his hand used to fit in mine.

there are more emojis on a dog video
i posted in 2017.

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last week, i replied 6 hearts to someone
who complimented my shirt.

i'm 24 and my dad is dead
and everyone is busy going to work
and paying their bills
and going to class
and typing out novels about their favorite ice cream

and i sit there, with my 7 hearts,
each point digging into my arm
as i cry on my couch alone.

(Pg 12-13) MY DAD DIED A WEEK AGO *(excerpts)*

and i kiss the top of his urn like i kissed his dead forehead
in the moment after. the feeling of his skin under my lips,
chalked with cooling sweat.
i stand in the middle of a field and pretend to pray.
i chicken out halfway to belief . . . i make belief.

cremation doesn't actually produce ash.
instead, the skin and muscle burn away entirely,
leaving just the weakened skeleton,

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which is thrown into a blender,
crushed, and returned to you.

(Pg 29) A HAND BECOMES *(excerpt)*

my dad doesn't have a grave except the one inside my
lungs.
i visit the cemetery anyway.
i sit next to the oldest gravestone and open up a book to
read.
i say out loud, *hello,* and am always surprised when no one
answers.

(Pg 13) MY DAD DIED A WEEK AGO *(excerpt)*

. . . after he died, the summer was gone,
and now, all i can do is wait.
i walk into his room and fold up his glasses.
they creak like they are still expecting a face.

(Pg 16-17) I WATCHED HIM DIE *(excerpt)*

i think the last thing he said to me was
*don't pour water down my f****ing throat,*
but i don't remember because he stopped
being able to talk two days before he died.

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this was a "peaceful" death, but, when they say
"peaceful," they mean compared to, like, being stabbed
to death
with 600 tiny forks. the truth is, the body wants
to live, and so there is always gasping.

(Pg 18) . . . the body tries to live every single second before
it can't.
(from If the Cells That Make Up Hair are Already Dead)

(Pg 32) THAT'S WHAT YOU SWALLOW WHEN YOU LET YOUR GRAVES OVERFLOW *(excerpt)*

your sister says, *i almost hope he chooses to die.*
and you know she doesn't just almost hope it
but that she actually *does* hope it,
because it's been 5 years and we are all so tired.
tired of calling the nurse, calling off work, crying into a
pillow.
tired of digging the grave so many times
our backyards have become cemeteries.

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(Pg 29) A HAND BECOMES *(excerpt)*

i hold his hand until it is time to unwrap the life from his
body,
to unwrap my father from a corpse.

i keep coming back to this moment of dying.
how it was not like what i had expected.
there was no last word, no wisdom,
no wind, nothing to blow open our grief,
no soundtrack except the cough
of the man dying in the room next door.

some people say their dead looked so peaceful
they could swear they were sleeping.
for my father, it was the other way around.
for months, every time he slept,
i could swear he was already dead.

i watched my dad die. [and now]

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(Pg 16-17) I WATCHED HIM DIE *(excerpt)*

my hands don't know how to sit still.
they want to be adjusting his glasses
and bringing a tissue to his nose
and pouring him a drink
and brushing his hair, and you know what?

i loved holding his hand.
i loved tucking him in.
i loved kissing his forehead before i said goodbye.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Ollie Schminkey
ISBN: 978-1943735938
Publisher: Button Poetry
Date (Month/Year): May 2021

AWARD HISTORY

MN State Qualifier

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